



Sociology 101: Social Institutions in Practice — A Full Case-Comparison Session

Sociology 101 · Sociology

COURSE-OBJ.SOC101.2

Apply core sociological concepts (social institution, norm, social capital) to analyze and compare how two real-feeling communities respond to the same type of disruption. A complete 90-minute session packet with warm-up, guided practice, partner/lab work, independent practice, extension work, assessment, and a full answer key.

PRINT • TEACH • REVISIT



Plan the session

Course and objective

Sociology 101 · Sociology; COURSE-OBJ.SOC101.2 — Apply the sociological concepts of social institutions, norms, and social capital to compare how two different communities respond to the same disruption.

What is included

Cover; instructor guide; key-term and concept preview; original reading or worked examples; warm-up (2 items); guided practice with organizer (4 items); partner/lab discussion (3 items); independent practice (6 items); small-group extension work (4 items); assessment; complete answer key; access and sources page.

Suggested pacing (90-minute session)

Warm-up 8 min · read both case files + vocabulary 15 min · guided institution/norm organizer 18 min · partner comparison discussion 18 min · independent practice 22 min · extension work 5 min · assessment 4 min.

Preparation

Print student pages separately from the answer key, or distribute through a secure LMS. Review the reading/examples and organizer before class. No paid textbook or app is required.

Student directions

Read or work through the material carefully. Support every answer with evidence, work shown, or clear reasoning.



Before you begin

Key terms

social institution — an established, patterned set of practices around a core need

norm — a shared expectation for behavior within a group

social capital — networks of relationships and trust that enable collective action

formal enforcement — a written rule or official consequence for a norm violation

informal enforcement — social disapproval or reaction, not an official rule

overlapping network — the same individuals connecting multiple institutions at once

Concept focus

A social institution is an established, patterned set of practices organized around a core social need — family, education, religion, government, and the economy are classic examples. Norms are shared expectations for behavior within a group, enforced through informal reactions (a raised eyebrow) or formal rules (a law). Social capital refers to the networks of relationships and mutual trust that let people and communities get things done together; it is distinct from financial capital, since two communities with similar incomes can have very different levels of it. Sociologists often compare communities responding to the same type of event (a flood, plant closure, or crisis) to see how existing institutions, norms, and social capital shape different outcomes even under similar pressure.

Model 1 — Identifying a social institution in action

When a town's volunteer fire department organizes a fundraiser after a family loses their home to fire, "volunteer fire department" and "neighborhood fundraising" both function as institutions — patterned, expected community responses, not one-time individual actions.

Model 2 — Distinguishing social capital from financial capital

Two neighborhoods each raise \$2,000 after a similar loss. In Neighborhood A, the money came from 200 small individual donations coordinated through existing community group texts. In Neighborhood B, it came from one wealthy donor. Both raised the same amount, but Neighborhood A shows more social capital — a dense network capable of coordinating collective action.

WARM-UP

Warm-up

Answer using what you already know or recall from the previous session.

1. Define "social institution" using the lesson's definition, then name two examples from Case File 1.

2. What new norm developed in Riverbend after the flood, and how does it fit the lesson's definition of a norm?



Case File 1: Riverbend After the Flood

When the river overflowed its banks last spring, Riverbend lost power for four days and saw four blocks of homes flooded. Within hours, the town's existing institutions activated in familiar, patterned ways: the volunteer fire department, already organized and equipped, went door to door checking on elderly residents; the two churches on Main Street, which had coordinated a joint food pantry for a decade, opened their doors as emergency shelters without needing new instructions; and the parent-teacher association, which normally organizes school fundraisers, redirected its existing phone tree and group chat to coordinate donated clothing and supplies within a single afternoon.

A sociologist studying the recovery later noted that Riverbend's response was fast not because any single organization was unusually well-funded, but because its residents had pre-existing, trusted relationships across several institutions at once — the fire department volunteers were often also church members and PTA parents, meaning information and resources moved through overlapping networks instead of starting from scratch. Within three weeks, informal norms also shifted: neighbors who previously kept spare keys only for close friends began routinely offering them to more distant neighbors "just in case," a new, lasting norm the town had not had before the flood.



Case File 2: Millbrook After the Flood

The same storm system flooded Millbrook, a town of similar size about forty miles away, with comparable property damage. But Millbrook's recovery looked different. The town had no volunteer fire department — fire and emergency response were contracted out to a regional company based two counties away, and while professionally competent, the crews had no pre-existing relationships with Millbrook residents and left once immediate danger had passed. Millbrook's three churches did not have a history of coordinating with each other, and each opened separately, duplicating some efforts (two shelters within a block of each other) while leaving other needs, like transportation for elderly residents without cars, unaddressed by any institution.

Millbrook did eventually recover, but more slowly: it took closer to six weeks for donated supplies to be efficiently distributed, partly because no single existing network had the trust and reach to coordinate across the town's separate institutions quickly. A local sociologist observed that Millbrook was not poorer than Riverbend, and its individual institutions (the churches, the school) were each reasonably resourced — what differed was the density of overlapping relationships connecting those institutions to each other, which is to say, its stock of social capital.



1. Explain why the sociologist in Case File 1 says Riverbend's fast response was not mainly about funding.
2. Identify one specific institution in Millbrook that functioned differently than its counterpart in Riverbend, and explain the difference.
3. What specific problem did Millbrook's three separate, uncoordinated churches cause, according to the case file?
4. Using the lesson's definition, explain why the sociologist calls the difference between Riverbend and Millbrook a difference in "social capital" rather than financial capital.

Partner / lab discussion

Discuss each item with a partner or lab group before writing a joint response.

1. With a partner, discuss: in Model 2 (the \$2,000 fundraiser example), why does the lesson call Neighborhood A's outcome a stronger example of social capital even though both neighborhoods raised the same amount?

2. With a partner, identify one institution in your own community (real or realistic) and describe one norm associated with it.

3. Discuss: the lesson says norms are enforced "informally" or "formally." Give one informal and one formal example of norm enforcement from either case file or your own knowledge.



Independent practice

Work independently. Show your work or cite evidence in every answer.

1. Predict what might happen if Riverbend experienced a second, unrelated crisis (e.g., a job-loss wave) one year after the flood. Use evidence from Case File 1 to justify your prediction.

2. Propose one specific, realistic change Millbrook could make to build more social capital between its institutions before the next crisis.

3. Explain the relationship between "overlapping networks" (people who are fire volunteers AND church members AND PTA parents) and the speed of Riverbend's recovery, using the case file's own reasoning.



Independent practice

Work independently. Show your work or cite evidence in every answer.

4. A classmate claims "Millbrook's problem was that its churches and schools were badly run." Evaluate this claim using evidence from Case File 2.

5. Write a two-to-three sentence comparison of Riverbend and Millbrook that uses all three vocabulary terms (institution, norm, social capital) correctly.

6. Design an original short scenario (not a flood) showing how social capital could speed or slow a community's response to a different type of disruption (e.g., a factory closing, a school redistricting).



Small-group extension work

Use for review or additional application practice.

1. Explain why a sociologist would study two similar towns experiencing the same disruption, rather than studying just one town in isolation.

2. Identify one limitation of this two-case comparison: what is one factor, other than social capital, that could also explain the different recovery speeds?



Small-group extension work

Use for learners ready for additional challenge or synthesis.

1. Write a short paragraph (4-5 sentences) explaining, in your own words, why sociologists distinguish "social capital" as its own concept separate from wealth or income.

2. Explain how the PTA's "existing phone tree and group chat" in Riverbend is itself an example of social capital being put to a new use.



Assessment

Complete independently to show what you learned today.

1. Self-assessment: which of the three vocabulary terms (institution, norm, social capital) do you feel you could explain most confidently to someone outside class, and which needs more review?



Assessment · self-assessment

Rate today's work:

4 — I can teach this to someone else.

3 — I can do this independently.

2 — I can do this with help.

1 — I need to revisit this before the next session.



Answer key

1. A social institution is an established, patterned set of practices organized around a core social need; examples from Case File 1 include the volunteer fire department, the churches' food pantry/shelter coordination, and the PTA's phone tree.
2. Neighbors began routinely offering spare keys to more distant neighbors "just in case" — this fits the definition of a norm because it became a shared, patterned expectation of behavior within the community that had not existed before.
3. The sociologist attributes the speed to pre-existing, overlapping trusted relationships across institutions (the same people being fire volunteers, church members, and PTA parents), not to any institution having unusually large financial resources.
4. The fire/emergency response: Riverbend had a local volunteer department with pre-existing relationships to residents; Millbrook contracted out to a regional company with no pre-existing local relationships, which left once immediate danger passed.
5. They duplicated some efforts (two shelters within a block of each other) while leaving other needs, like transportation for elderly residents without cars, unaddressed by any institution.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

6. The sociologist explicitly says Millbrook was not poorer than Riverbend and its individual institutions were reasonably resourced; what differed was the density of overlapping relationships connecting institutions to each other, which is what the lesson defines as social capital, distinct from financial resources.

7. Neighborhood A's funds came from 200 coordinated small donations through existing community networks, demonstrating a dense, functioning network capable of collective action; Neighborhood B's single large donation does not demonstrate the same network capacity, even though the financial outcome was identical.

8. Answers vary; must name a genuine or realistic institution (school, place of worship, local government, workplace) and a specific associated norm (an expected behavior within that institution).

9. Answers vary; must correctly distinguish informal enforcement (social disapproval, a raised eyebrow, gossip) from formal enforcement (a written rule, a law, an official consequence), using a real or realistic example.

10. Riverbend would likely respond relatively effectively again, since the case file shows its overlapping institutional networks and trust-based norms (like the new key-sharing norm) persisted and are not flood-specific, suggesting the underlying social capital could be mobilized for a different kind of disruption too.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

11. Answers vary; must propose a specific, plausible mechanism for building overlapping relationships between institutions, e.g., the three churches establishing a joint coordination committee, or the school inviting emergency responders to regular community events.

12. Because the same individuals belonged to multiple institutions at once, information and resources could move directly through personal trust relationships across institutional lines instead of each institution having to coordinate from scratch with unfamiliar counterparts — this is what let Riverbend act quickly and cohesively.

13. The case file explicitly states Millbrook's individual institutions were "each reasonably resourced," so the claim is not well supported; the actual problem identified was the lack of coordination and overlapping relationships between institutions, not poor management of any single one.

14. Answers vary; must use all three terms accurately in a coherent comparison of the two towns' flood responses.

15. Answers vary; must describe a specific disruption and explain how the presence or absence of overlapping institutional relationships plausibly affects the community's response, using the lesson's logic.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

16. Comparing two similar cases responding to the same type of event helps isolate what actually explains the difference in outcomes (in this case, social capital) by holding other factors (the type of disruption, town size, general resource level) roughly constant.

17. Answers vary; must propose a plausible alternative or confounding factor, e.g., differences in the severity or exact timing of flooding, differences in local government resources, or differences in how many days each town had advance warning.

18. Answers vary; must explain that financial resources and network/trust resources are distinct kinds of capital that can vary independently, and that both can meaningfully shape outcomes like disaster recovery, sometimes with network capital mattering as much as or more than money.

19. The phone tree and group chat were built for routine school fundraising, but because they represented an already-trusted, functioning communication network, that same network could be redirected almost instantly to flood relief — showing how existing social capital transfers to new purposes rather than needing to be rebuilt each time.

20. Answers vary; must name one term for each part with a genuine reason.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Access, sources, and license

Extension

Ask for a second method, a counterexample, or a short student-led extension of the concept, with a brief explanation of the choice.

Accommodated seating/504

Follow the individual accommodation plan: extended time, breaks, enlarged print, reduced copying, or an alternate response method as documented.

Additional support

Pre-teach key vocabulary or notation before class. Model the first guided item aloud. Accept oral or dictated responses when appropriate.

Multilingual learners

Preview key terms with examples. Allow brief first-language discussion before independent writing. Provide sentence or solution starters.

Course-level alignment · accessed September 18, 2026

COURSE-OBJ.SOC101.2 — Apply the sociological concepts of social institutions, norms, and social capital to compare how two different communities respond to the same disruption. The objective is original wording describing a focused part of the course-level goal.

Course-level learning objective written for this packet; no accreditation, transfer credit, or universal course-equivalency is claimed.

Original reading(s)/worked examples, questions, and answer explanations. No textbook or copyrighted course material reproduced.

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